

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, morning snow and rain, afternoon clouds, not as cold, high 42. Tonight, cloudy, low 32. Tomorrow, cloudy, afternoon snow and rain, high 38. Weather map, Page A16.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



LYNSEY ADDARIO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Despite being about 12 miles from the front, Sloviansk is bustling, as many soldiers quartered there buy flowers for their partners.

Reliance on Taiwan Chips Endangers U.S. Economy

Big Tech Has Done Little to Heed Warnings of Disaster if China Attacks Island

By TRIPP MICKLE

Federal officials have for years tried to wean Silicon Valley from its dependence on Taiwan, an island democracy roughly the size of Maryland that makes 90 percent of the world's high-end computer chips.

In secret briefings held in Washington and Silicon Valley, national security officials warned executives from companies like Apple, Advanced Micro Devices and Qualcomm that China was making plans to retake Taiwan, which Beijing has long considered a breakaway territory. A Chinese blockade of Taiwan, the officials said, could choke the supply of computer chips made on the island and bring the U.S. tech industry to its knees.

Two presidents have tried persuading the industry to change. President Joseph R. Biden Jr. offered financial grants worth billions to improve the domestic production of chips. After that didn't work, President Trump threatened billions in tariffs to essentially accomplish the same thing.

But warnings, gifts and threats have made little difference. The U.S. tech industry has stubbornly refused to shift where it gets most of its chips, which power things like smartphones, laptops and the giant data centers that run artificial intelligence.

Now, there is increasing concern that inaction by some of Silicon Valley's most important companies risks destabilizing the global economy. Those worries,

drawn into focus by recent live-fire drills conducted by the Chinese military in waters surrounding Taiwan, have prompted dire warnings from White House officials.

“The single biggest threat to the world economy, the single biggest point of single failure, is that 97 percent of the high-end chips are made in Taiwan,” Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said last month at the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland, slightly overstating industry estimates. “If that island were blockaded, that capacity were destroyed, it would be an economic apocalypse.”

If Taiwan is lost, the tech industry won't be able to say it wasn't warned. A New York Times investigation found that executives were so focused on winning in their hypercompetitive markets and maintaining big profit margins that facing up to the Taiwan problem was an afterthought. And now it will be years before the steps some companies are finally taking make a difference.

A confidential report commissioned in 2022 by the Semiconductor Industry Association for its members, which include the largest U.S. chip companies, said cutting the supply of chips from Taiwan would lead to the largest economic crisis since the Great Depression. U.S. economic output would plunge 11 percent, twice as much as in the 2008 recession. The collapse would be even more severe.

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Epstein Sought Customs Perks For Private Isle

By DAVID ENRICH and STEVE EDER

One of Jeffrey Epstein's greatest skills was building and exploiting connections with those who had the power to help or hinder him. In the U.S. Virgin Islands, that included the federal Customs and Border Protection officers who inspected the people and goods that were going to and from his private hideaway.

Mr. Epstein dispensed food, helicopter rides, financial advice and even musical gigs to a handful of C.B.P. officers stationed on St. Thomas, the American port of entry that was near Little St. James, an island that Mr. Epstein owned.

At the same time, Mr. Epstein enjoyed concierge services from some of the customs officers in St. Thomas, according to emails and other records recently released by the Justice Department. They whisked him through inspections. And they helped him troubleshoot when he encountered problems at airports on the mainland.

Starting in 2019, those chummy relationships became the subject of a criminal investigation, the records show.

Agents from the Federal Bureau of Investigation and the Department of Homeland Security, as well as federal prosecutors, spent more than a year looking into whether C.B.P. officers in St. Thomas allowed Mr. Epstein and his guests to avoid scrutiny as they entered the country.

The outcome of the investigation, which focused on at least four C.B.P. officers, including a supervisor, is unclear. There is no record of any charges.

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ACADEMIC TIES A behavioral scientist at Duke sought out Jeffrey Epstein for his research, their correspondence shows. PAGE B1



ADRIANA ZEBBRAUSKAS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES
ICE plans a detention center at a warehouse in Surprise, Ariz.

They're for ICE, But Go NIMBY On Warehouses

This article is by Madeleine Ngo, Hamed Aleaziz and Allison McCann.

WASHINGTON — Stacy Bradley voted for President Trump because of his border policies, and she likes that he has restored “law and order.” But she is unsettled by one aspect of his immigration agenda.

Last month, the federal government bought a warehouse next to her cheerleading gym in Surprise, Ariz., which the administration plans to convert into a detention center for up to 1,500 immigrants.

Ms. Bradley, the co-owner of Woodlands Elite Cheer, said she worried that a detainee could escape, or that protests could break out. The children who train at her gym are as young as 3 and could see “people in shackles” next door, she said.

“That’s a scary thing for a little kid to process,” Ms. Bradley said.

Across the country, the Department of Homeland Security's plans to buy industrial warehouses and turn them into detention centers for immigrants are running into local resistance, including in communities like Surprise.

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Mexico Facing Two-Part Test

Pressed by Trump and Threatened by Cartels

By JACK NICAS

MEXICO CITY — El Mencho was the biggest kingpin left. The drug lord, whose real name was Nemesio Oseguera Cervantes, had evaded capture for two decades, outlasting his rivals El Chapo and El Mayo and building his Jalisco New Generation Cartel into Mexico's most powerful criminal organization.

Then, over the weekend, his run came to an abrupt end, in part because of a romantic rendezvous.

The killing was a clear success for the Mexican authorities. The timing, however, seemed to be telling.

President Trump has been loudly and repeatedly demanding that Mexican officials dismantle the cartels that have amassed fortunes by sending drugs across the border. If they don't, he has threatened, the U.S. military may do the job instead.

Those threats appear to be having an effect.

President Claudia Sheinbaum of Mexico has overseen one of the most aggressive offensives against the cartels in more than a decade.

On Sunday, weeks after Mr. Trump ordered a military intervention in Venezuela and warned that Mexico was next, Ms. Sheinbaum took another bold swing. She authorized Mexican forces to take out her nation's most wanted criminal, using intelligence provided by the United States.

The killing of Mr. Oseguera shows how the tense interplay between Mr. Trump and Ms. Sheinbaum — two leaders with starkly different styles but an unlikely camaraderie — has fundamentally reshaped the U.S.-Mexico relationship, particularly on security.

“The pressure that Trump has put on her administration has been a force she's taken advantage of,” Ms. Sheinbaum said.

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State of the Union

President Trump was set to address Congress at a time of fundamental change in the United States. Coverage at nytimes.com.

Not Wanting to Be Traded ‘Like Cattle’ for Peace

By ANDREW E. KRAMER

SLOVIANSK, Ukraine — Daria Bondareva gushes with enthusiasm for the beauty salon she opened two years ago, fulfilling a dream to run her own business. It is a warm, well-lit space, drawing a steady stream of clients.

And she does not want it handed over to Russia, along with the rest of the Donetsk region in eastern Ukraine, where she has lived her whole life. Four years into a war that Moscow began with a lightning invasion on Feb. 24, 2022, this is the essential trade being offered to Kyiv in talks brokered by the Trump administration. Surrender Donetsk, Ukraine has been told, and in exchange get

Ukrainians in Donetsk Fear Region Being Handed to Russia

a promise of peace in the rest of the country.

Ms. Bondareva, 28, has little faith that Russia would abide by any agreement. For her, that makes the idea of giving up territory that Moscow has demanded but failed to conquer an unfathomable risk.

“I don't think Ukraine will ever agree to this,” she said. “I don't know what will need to happen for Ukraine to agree to give us up.”

As fighting continues to rage

along hundreds of miles of front line, Russia and Ukraine are engaging in near-weekly peace talks. Negotiators have narrowed their differences largely to two core issues: control of Donetsk and guarantees of Ukraine's postwar security.

The talks about territory are driven by Russia's slow but seemingly inevitable advances. The argument by those pushing Ukraine to relinquish the territory is that Kyiv will eventually lose it militarily anyway, so it should go ahead and cede the area and potentially end the killing.

President Volodymyr Zelensky has said that Ukraine will not unilaterally withdraw from Donetsk, a territory that thousands of

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JUAN ARREDONDO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

North Star Academy Washington Park High School in Newark started a new A.I. class for seniors.

A.I. Literacy Lesson: Don't Let It Think for You

By NATASHA SINGER

The first session of a new artificial intelligence class this month for high school seniors in Newark involved purely human intelligence.

The students' assignment: to compare when they had passively scrolled through A.I.-driven social media feeds with times when they had actively selected the videos or Google search results they wanted to see.

“Are you steering the technology or is it steering you?” asked a

Schools Stick Students in the Driver's Seat

slide on the classroom whiteboard at Washington Park High School.

In a class discussion that followed, a student named Adrian Farrell, 18, said he had taken charge of A.I. by asking a chatbot to check his math homework for accuracy. Brianna Perez, 18, said she went into “passenger mode” when using a Spotify feature

called A.I. DJ. “It plays your favorite music so you don't have to change it,” she said.

Schools across the United States are hustling to introduce a new subject: A.I. literacy.

In what some educators are calling a “driver's license” for A.I., the new lessons aim to teach students how to examine the latest tech tools and use them responsibly. Teachers say they want to prepare young people to navigate a world increasingly shaped by A.I., as chatbots manufacture human-like voices and generate images.

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Putting Poetry Underground

Judith Chernaik's idea to feature verse in subway cars has transformed the commutes of millions. PAGE A4

Iranians Brace for War

Stores are well stocked, but many people are in limbo as they wait to see whether the U.S. will attack. PAGE A11

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Congressman Pressed to Quit

Tony Gonzales of Texas is urged to step down after allegations that he had coerced a sexual relationship with an aide who later killed herself. PAGE A21

Protecting the Homeless

Mayor Zohran Mamdani said he's taken lessons from New York's last storm, when at least 20 people died. PAGE A14

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A Modern-Day Thoreau

Edward Hoagland, a revered essayist on natural wonders, also explored the inner terrain of his life. He was 93. PAGE B11



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'I Am in Two Waters'

The conductor Gustavo Dudamel prepares to leave Los Angeles and its Philharmonic for New York's. PAGE C1

Tyra Banks on the Defensive

A new docuseries confronts the onetime “Top Model” host with the cringe-worthy claims of series contestants. PAGE C1

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Are U.S. Taxes Anti-Feminist?

Academics have tried to reimagine how our tax laws could be transformed to be more equitable and attentive toward caregivers. PAGE B1

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On the Mound for the U.S.

Some of the top American pitchers are finally participating in the World Baseball Classic, showing the event's growing importance. PAGE B7

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Elizabeth Spiers

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Should I Refrigerate Apples?

Select and store fruits and vegetables to maximize taste and minimize waste. Here's a shopping basket full of tips and some cooking ideas. PAGE D6

